

reading? And to what text-type do those MSS belong? And why did they use that text-type?

Quite apart from the Talmud, we know from the NT that it was the custom in the Jewish synagogues to read from the OT writings in their Sabbath meetings. The Lord Jesus Himself did this, as recorded in Luke 4:16-19. At the 'Jerusalem Council' James concluded his decision with: "For from ancient generations Moses has in every city those who preach him, being read in the synagogues every Sabbath" (Acts 15:21). The apostle Paul always began his ministry in a new city with the Jewish synagogue, when there was one. Notice what Acts 13:15 says: "After the reading of the Law and the Prophets, the synagogue leaders sent to them..." In a synagogue Paul usually began his speech with: "Men of Israel and you who fear God", the 'you who fear God' referring to Gentiles who were present.

Now in the very beginning the Christian community was mainly made up of Jews and such Gentiles, and they would naturally continue the practice of reading Scripture in their weekly meetings. Recall what gave rise to the office of deacon in Acts 6. "It is not advantageous that we should forsake the Word of God to serve at tables" (verse 2). "We will give ourselves continually to prayer and to the ministry of the Word" (verse 4). Of course, at that time their Bible was the OT; the first Gospel, Matthew, not being published until 38/39. However, since the NT writings were recognized as Scripture from the very first, it was natural that they would be added to the OT, and in time probably took the lead. Notice what Justin Martyr wrote in his First Apology (around 150 AD):

On the day called Sunday, all who live in cities or in the country gather together in one place, and the memoirs of the Apostles or the writings of the prophets are read, as long as time permits; then, when the reader has ceased, the president [presiding minister] verbally instructs and exhorts to the imitation of these good things.¹

The "memoirs of the Apostles" were the Gospels as we know them (First Apology 66). If one considers Justin's use of the phrase "memoirs of the Apostles" in all of his writings, one may safely conclude that he accurately refers to two apostles (Matthew and John) and two followers of the apostles (Mark and Luke), which he delineated. Justin used the phrase

¹ Roberts, Alexander and Donaldson, James, eds. *The Ante-Nicean Fathers*. American Edition. New York: Christian Literature Co., 1906. I. p. 186.